



BETTER

CHESS



The magazine that

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Issue **3**

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TACTICAL analysis

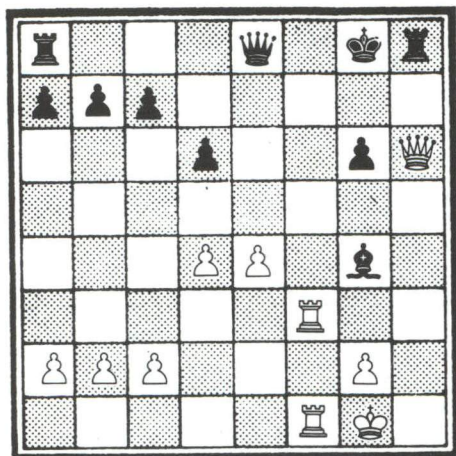
The ability to analyse and solve tactical positions can help you to become a strong player, though there are other factors involved.

Tactics always underlies chess thinking, as it can surface any time during a game. Tactics becomes dominant at certain stages of the game - when one side has built up such a superiority that a decisive combination is available; or sometimes both sides have built up superiorities in different areas of the board and then a lightning storm is imminent.

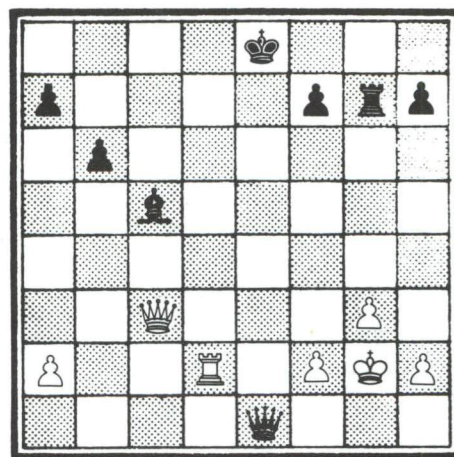
Playing good tactics requires:-

- (a) a general knowledge of various themes and typical positions - pins, forks, skewers, discoveries, etc. This knowledge can be gained by working through hundreds of puzzles in books on elementary tactics.
- (b) ability to analyse in the head. Many players complain of being unable to 'see ahead'. This problem is compounded by not knowing what they are supposed to look for. When solving tactical positions, the pieces should not be moved around the board; this forces the brain to visualise; you need to ensure that this does not give you a headache! Having done many hundreds of positions in this way, you should also get a better idea of what to look for. For example, a solver of 2 move chess problems gets to know that the first move is never a check; and he also starts to look for moves that set up batteries, or give the enemy pieces or king more freedom. Similarly, a solver of tactical puzzles starts to look for unexpected moves, checks, captures, threats and sacrifices.
- (c) The ability to 'juggle' variations in the head is vital. Certain ideas can be seen in a position but it is a question of arranging and re-arranging the moves in different orders until the actual solution is found.
- (d) caution. This is vital - having found a promising continuation, you should look hard for black's best defences and try to overcome them. Too many tactical solutions have been flawed because the player thought it was 'too easy'.
- (e) accuracy - very important. You can develop this by keeping good track of the material situation so that you know at each stage how much you are ahead or behind on material. Accuracy can also be shown by your ability to 'juggle', and thus spot the difference between various lines of play.
- (f) an appreciation that too much tactics can seriously damage your over the board play. You need the patience to build up a position, the willingness to play endgames where you are converting a small advantage of a pawn to a victory. Tactical ability needs to be blended in with other vital playing ingredients, patience and positional sense.

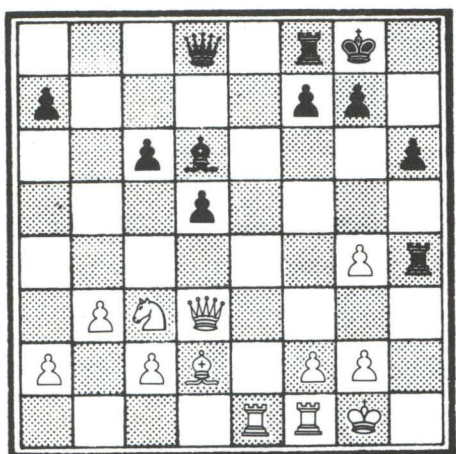
The next six positions show simple tactics. If you can solve them easily, go on to the harder positions in the rest of the article. If you want more practice get a copy of Gillam's Simple Tactics, or Paul Littlewood's 'Chess Tactics', and study them. Solutions on page 4.



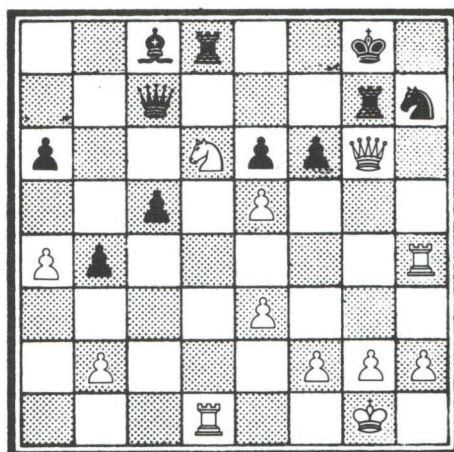
1. White to play



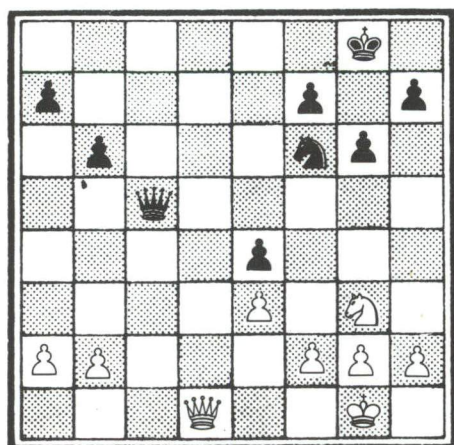
2. White to play



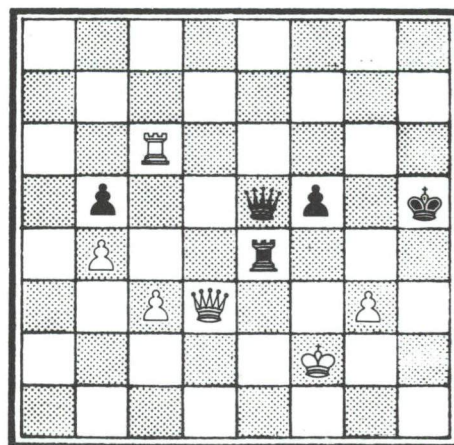
3. Black to play



4. White to play



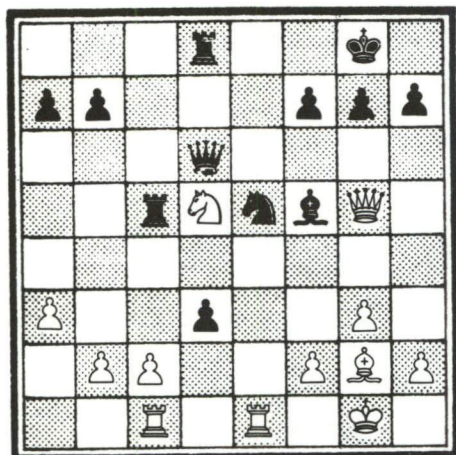
5. White to play



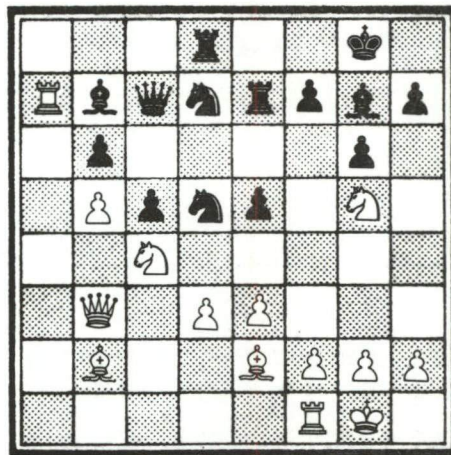
6. White to play

2. Difficult tactical positions:

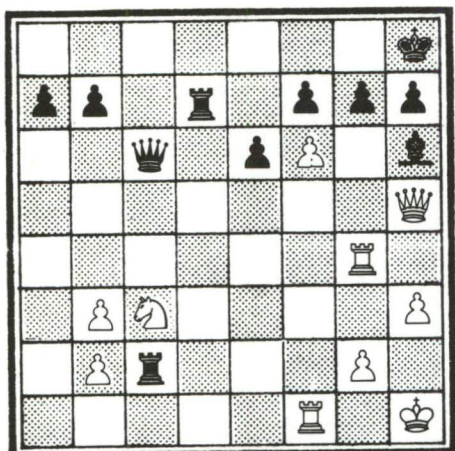
With the harder positions, you should write down the thoughts and variations you had when you were trying to solve them and then compare them with the detailed solutions.



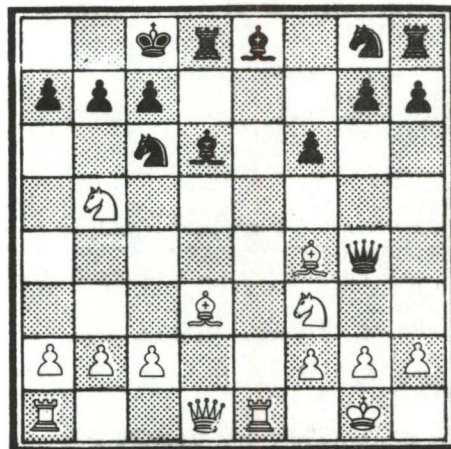
1. Black to play



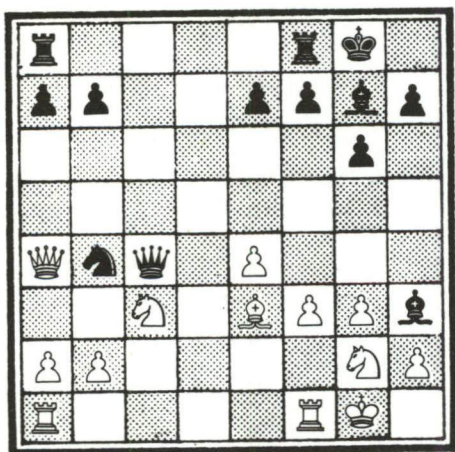
2. White to play



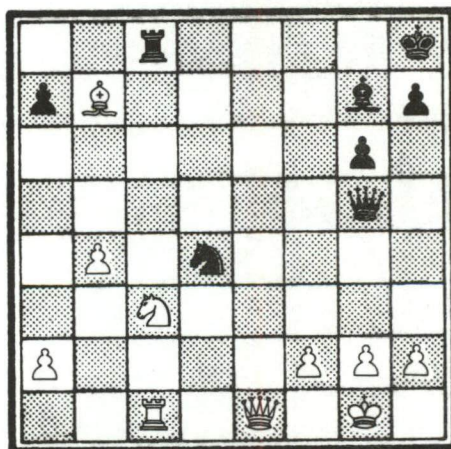
3. White to play



4. White to play



5. Black to play



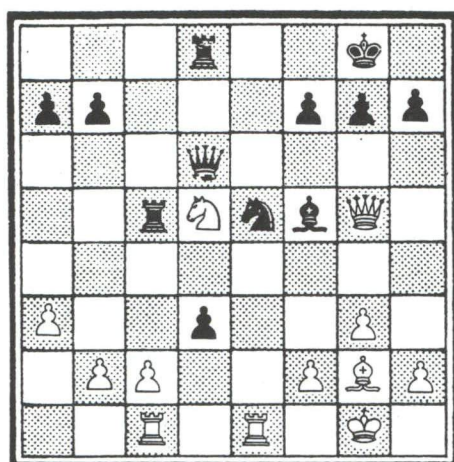
6. Black to play

Solutions to simple tactical puzzles:

1. 1. Rf8+ Qxf8 2. Rxf8+ Rxf8 3. Qxg6mate. The 'epaulette' mate.
2. 1. Rd8+ Kxd8 2. Qxel, but not 1. Qxg7 Qxd2.
3. 1...Bh2+ 2 Kh1 Bg3+ 3. Kgl Rh1+ 4. Kxhl Qh4+ 5. Kgl Qh2 mate, but not 1...Rh1+ 2. Kxhl Qh4+ 3. Qh3.
4. 1. Rxh7 Rxg6 2. Rxc7 Bd7 3. Nb7 winning a piece.
5. 1. Qd8+ Kg7 2. Qxf6+ Kxf6 3. Nxe4+ Ke5 4. Nxc5 bxc5 with a winning king and pawn ending. White must first centralise his king.
6. 1. Qdl+! Rg4 2. Qhl+ Kg5 3. Qh6 mate; or 1...Kg5 2. Qcl+ f4 3. Rc5. A tricky puzzle; near tries are 1 g4+, 1 Qf3+ or 1 Rc5, all of which fail.

SOLUTIONS TO DIFFICULT TACTICAL POSITIONS

Position 1.



Thoughts: Possible pawn fork by d2. Bishop enprise at f5. 1...Rxd5 may win two pieces for a rook. Rook at d8 is loose if the black queen moves away.

Maybe 1...Rxd5. If 2.Qxf5 d2; or if 1...Rxd5 2.Bxd5 Qxd5 3. Qxf5 black has a discovery here - Nf3+ - winning the white queen. However, this looks too easy. Is there a flaw here?

Yes; 1...Rxd5 2.Bxd5 Qxd5 3.Rxe5 Qxe5 4. Qxd8 - that back row mate turns up.

Mulls it over. Maybe play the moves in another order; 1...d2 2. Qxd2 Rxd5 winning two pieces for the rook. Maybe white can also play his moves in another order.

1...d2 2.Ne7+ Kh8 3.Nxf5 dxe1 =Q+ 4. Rxe1 Qf6. Messy, though black is still winning.

Ah! wait a minute. Maybe another move order; 1...Rxd5 2.Bxd5 d2 3.Qxd2 Nf3+ (the bishop at d5 is pinned against the queen here) 4. Bxf3 Qxd2.

Or 1...Rxd5 2.Bxd5 d2 3.Qxf5 dxcl=Q 4. Rxcl Qxd5 - black is a piece ahead.

I think that's the solution.

Themes to solution:-

pawn fork at d2

ideas involving knight fork at f3

discovery (after 1...Rxd5 2.Bxd5 Qxd5 4. Qxf5? Nf3+)

pin (after 1...Rxd5 2. Bxd5 d2 3. Qxd2 Nf3+)

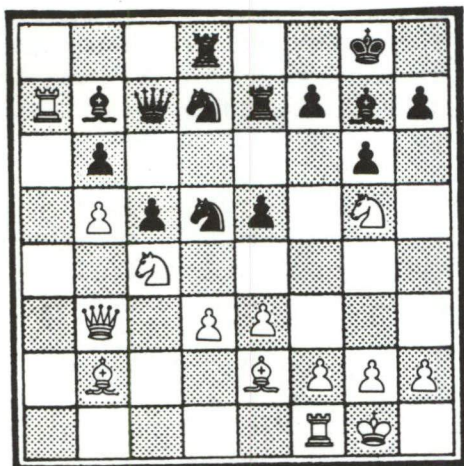
back row mate threat (Qxd8+)

General commentary; ability needed to analyse in the head.

ability to change the move orders 'juggle' to reach a better result.

cautious-ness - not being satisfied with the first plausible solution (1...Rxd5 2.Bxd5 Qxd5 3.Rxe5! and Qxd8+ which would fall into white's hidden trap.

Position 2.



Line of queen (at b3) and knight at g5 leading to f7. Pin by rook at a7.

Possible clearance sacrifice by Nxb6 or demolition sacrifice by Rxb7; or even Nxf7. Possible move e4 to dislodge knight at d5 and lead to f7 attack. But f7 is defended by rook at e7.

So 1.Rxb7 Qxb7 2. Nd6 Qa8 3.Ral looks good as white wins the knight at d5.

But 1.Rxb7 Qxb7 2. Nd6 Qc7 3. Qxd5 Nf6 gives black a counter pin here, winning the d6 knight.

Mulls it over. 1.e4 Nf4 attacks my bishop. 1. Nd6 Qxd6 2. Rxb7 - maybe.

Looks at 1.Nxe5 - but doesn't look promising because after 1.Nxe5 Nxe5 2. Bxe5 Bxe5 black is defending d5 from the rook at d8.

1. Rxb7 Qxb7 2. Nd6 still looks best though it is messy. 2... Qc7 3. Ngxf7 - maybe white can play this sacrifice. After 1.Rxb7 Qxb7 2. Nd6 Qc7 3.Ngxf7 Rxf7 4.Qxd5 Nf6 5. Qxf7+ Qxf7 6. Nxf7 Kxf7 white is a pawn up.

Still, black can reply 3...c4 after Ngxf7. Then 4.dxc4 is possibly still better for white.

1. Nd6 Qxd6 2. Rxb7 is a positional way to play - white weakens the white squares in the black camp by swapping the b7 bishop.

May be there is another way; 1. Nxf7; if Kxf7 of course 2.Rxb7 Qxb7 3. Nd6+ forking king and queen. If 1. Nxf7 Rxf7 2.Rxb7 Qxb7 3.Nd6 Qc7 4.Nxf7 Kxf7 5. Qxd5+ with white a pawn up and the black king exposed. This looks like the solution. Again if 1. Nxf7 Rxf7 2. Rxb7 Qxb7 3. Nd6 Qa8 4.Ral and the black queen has to leave guard of the knight at d5.

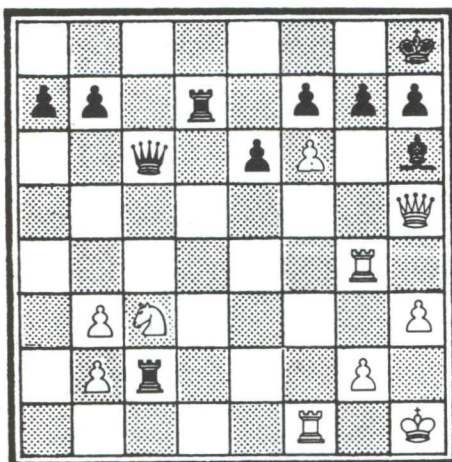
Themes:

lines of force leading to f7.
pin by rook at a7 (not used)
removal of defender (by Nd6 and Ral)
counter-pin by Nf6 after 1. Rxb7 Qxb7 2. Nd6 Qc7 3. Qxd5 Nf6
demolition and line opening sacrifice by Nxf7.
Knight forks at d6
loose black knight at d5.

General Commentary:- Main ability here is to see ideas and then change move orders to reach a better result.

The problem took several minutes to solve because the most successful move order (1.Nxf7) was not discovered till later. But the ingredients were all there. Accuracy of analysis also needed in the sense that the solver always had a good idea if he was material up or down, be it a pawn, a piece, the exchange, 2 pieces for a rook, a queen, etc...

Position 3.



King side attack; 1.fxg7+ possible. Black almost has a mate threat at g2.

White could play 1. Qxh6 and Rg8+ - no good. 1.Qxf7 is an idea. Also 1.Nd5 or Rxg7.

The simple 1. fxg7+ Bxg7 2.Rxf7 looks dodgy after 2...Rcl+. If 1.Rc4 Qxg2 mate.

Mulls it over. Can't see a way. Rook at c2 is loose. Spends maybe 5 minutes looking through the lines. Maybe there is a way by playing 1.fxg7+ Bxg7 2. Qg5 f5 (this was earlier rejected as too messy, but returns to it as nothing else is seen.

Now 3.Rc4 might work because the queen at g5 guards the pawn at g2. If 3...Qb6 4. Rc8+ white wins. Checks through variations.

1.fxg7+ Bxg7 2. Qg5 Bd4 3.Qg8++ Or 2...f6 3.Rxf6! Rcl+ no here white plays 4.Qcl; but then 4... Bxf6. So instead 4.Kh2 Qc7+ 5.Rg3 black has a ruined king position.

1.fxg7+ Bxg7 2.Qg5 f5 3.Rc4 Qd6 4.Rc8+ Bf8 5.Rdl is nasty. 2...f5 3. Rc4 h6 may be black's best chance. But still in trouble after 4. Qg6 Qb6 5. Qe8+ winning a rook; or 4...Qd6 or Qd5 5.Rdl (better than 5. Rc8+ Rd8 when black holds white off.)

That looks the best line (but not entirely happy.)

However, the book solution is not this but 1. Qe5, the double threat being Qb8+ and fxg7+.

It is possible that the solver also missed a black resource in the line 1.fxg7+ Bxg7 2. Qg5 f5 3. Rc4 Bh6; if now 4.Qxh6 Qxg2++; or 4. Rxc6 Bxg5 and black defends.

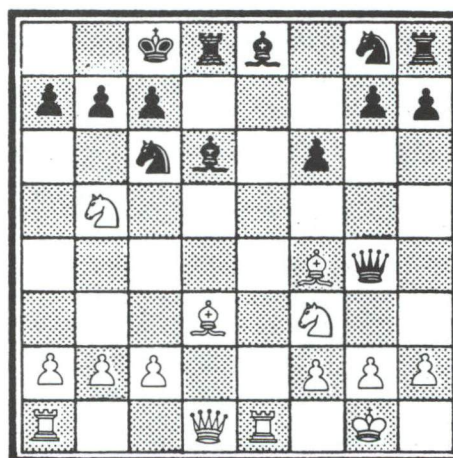
This puzzle was not really solved.

Themes:- mating attack
- back row mate
- necessity of considering black's counter play at g2
- switching of attack (by rook c4 and Rc8+)

Once again, general themes were spotted and moves were arranged and re-arranged until a promising pattern was found.

But a completely new idea - 1.Qe5 is overlooked as it is rather 'unlikely' looking.

Position 4.



Loose black queen at g4. Possible discovery. Possible fork by Bf5+.

White bishop at f4 is en prise. Black bishop at e8 is loose. Possible is 1.Bxd6 cxd6 2.Rxe8 Rxe8 3. Nxd6+ and Nxe8 - but this looks rather too easy.

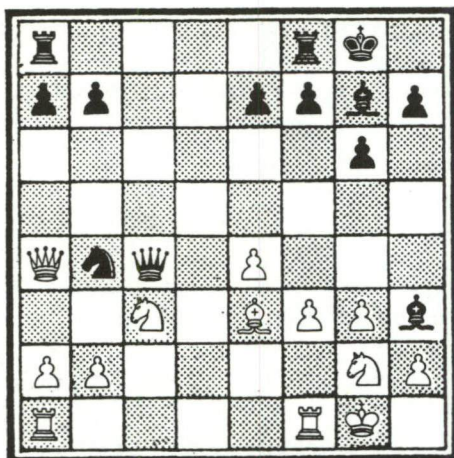
Why not flick in 3.Bf5+ Qxf5
4. Nxd6+ forking the queen as well. This looks fairly simple. Black is material down if he tries other defences, e.g. 1. Bxd6 a6 2. Bxc7; or 1. Bxd6 cxd6 2. Rxe8 a6 3. Rxd8+ and so on.

This looks very simple.

Themes:

- discoveries by Ne5 against queen at g4 (not used)
- fork (by Nxd6+)
- attraction (drawing a piece onto a bad square) by Bf5+
- sacrifice to deflect a piece from defending a square (Rxe8 deflecting the rook from d8).

Position 5.



Loose white king position. Strong black attack; possible discovery against white queen at a4. But knight at b4 is pinned. Knight at c3 guards the white queen at a4. Try 1... Bxc3 2.bxc3 Qe2 (threatening mate at g2) 3.Rf2 - no deal.

Try 1...Bd4 as well.

Mulls it over.

Another plan. 1...Bxg2 2. Kxg2 Bxc3 3. bxc3 Nc2. If 4. Qxc4 Nxe3+ forks all white's pieces. But after 3...Nc2 4. Qxc2. Any other knight discoveries? 3...Nd5 is better; 4.Qxc4 Nxe3+ still wins a piece.

The question now is are the moves in the right order? 1.Bxg2 first looks right; not 1...Bxc3 because after 2.bxc3 black's knight is attacked. Black could play 2... Qxc3 but winning a pawn might not be worth parting with a valuable defensive bishop at g7.

So 1...Bxg2 2. Kxg2 Bxc3 3.bxc3 - no in-between moves here.

If 3. Racl Qe2+ 4. Rf2 Qxe3 - black is a piece up or 4.Bf2 Bd2.

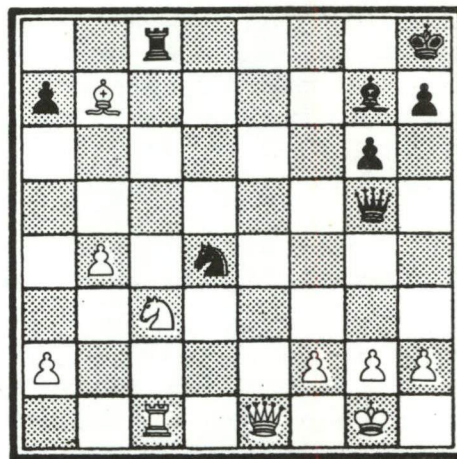
After 3. bxc3 Nd5, white can't move his queen to guard the bishop so must allow Nxe3+

That looks like the solution.

Themes:

- discovery by Nd5
- fork by Nxe3+
- loose pieces, Q at a4
- removing defender by Bxc3
- weak white king that can be used for combinations: (Nxe3+).

Position 6.



Ominous position of white king, with black queen at g5.

Possible Nf3+ fork.

Loose knight at c3. Rook at c8 threatens it, as does the bishop at g7, though this is hidden by a knight at d4.

Black rook at c8 is attacked by bishop at b7, though this cannot be taken due to the knight fork Nf3+.

Try 1. Rxc3 2. Rxc3 Ne2+. But
all these ideas are zapped after
1...Rxc3 2. Qxc1 Ne2+ 3.Nxe2
Rxc1 4. Nxcl - black is a piece
down.

Try 1...Qxc1 2. Qxc1 Rxc3. Now
white is a queen ahead but will
probably get mated.

If 3. Qxc3 Nxe2+ and Nxc3.

If 3. Q any Rcl+ 4.Qxc1 Ne2+
black is still a piece ahead
though white has two pawns and
may draw.

Themes: - back row mates at e8
and cl
- fork (Ne2+)
- attraction sacrifice.

From the Editor:-

This is, for the time being at least,
the last issue of Better Chess, since I no longer have time to write
it, print it, and sell it. The magazine, which began in 1978 as
Rabbits Review, has spanned 39 issues in all - 21 of Rabbits Review,
15 of Popular Chess, and 3 of Better Chess.

In every issue the underlying philosophy has
been the same - the average chessplayer does not have the time - and
maybe the capacity - for the copious and detailed analysis of other
chess publications. However, he is interested in improving his game!
So the emphasis has been on explanation - words rather than variations-
simplicity and clarity. There are always plenty of diagrams in the
magazine, which makes the text easier to follow; and frequently amateur
games are analysed rather than master games, because typical mistakes
occur in these games and not elsewhere.

The readership of Rabbits Review/Pop Chess/
Better Chess has always been small - 450 dropping to about 200. But
the idea remains a good one, even if the marketing was not!

N.B. It is possible that Victor Mathias, who
annotates many of his games in the magazine, will be taking over,
in which case the magazine would be better run, appear regularly,
and would retain some articles written by myself. So this may not be
the end.

Mike Basman, August 1989

Back issues of Rabbits Review 1-12 90p each £10.10 the set.

A4 size Rabbits Review 13-21 £1.20 each £9.00 the set.

Popular Chess 1-15 £1.20 each £15.00 the set.

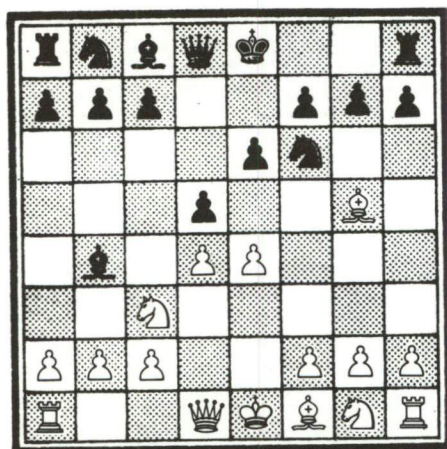
Better Chess 1-3 £1.30 each

From Audio Chess 7A Billockby Close, Chessington, Surrey KT9 2ED

1. P-K4 P-K3
2. P-Q4 P-Q4
3. N-QB3 N-KB3

The so-called Classical Variation which Alan employs to good effect.

4. B-N5 B-N5?!
- ...B-K2 is normal, to break the pin on the black knight.



NOTE A: Alan is actually playing the Maccutcheon variation, a counter attacking line which gives white more problems than the standard "Classical" variation, 4...B-K2.

By pinning the knight at c3, black threatens to win the pawn at e4, and white is unable to win the knight at f6 by playing pawn to e5 because of the counter attack on his bishop.

One line which is meant to be in black's favour (because he eliminates a white centre pawn and gains the two bishops) is 5P-K5 P-KR3 6PxN PxB 7PxP R-N1. However, this line has advantages for white too, due to black's slow development and cramped central position.

Another variation is 5P-K5 P-KR3 6B-Q2 BxN 7PxB N-K5 8Q-N4 P-KN3; and this complicated position is meant to be the main line. There is an Audio Chess tape devoted to the Maccutcheon. How did the opening get its name. It was first played in a simultaneous by a player called Maccutcheon,

against the then World Champion, Wilhelm Steinitz - and Maccutcheon won!

5. P-K5
- Alan later told me his heart sank when I played this as he, at first, thought he was going to lose a piece, but it turned out that he had a simple saving resource

5. ... P-KR3
6. BxN

After much thought. BxP would open up the h-file for Alan. My move breaks up his kingside-pawns, leaving him a weak h-pawn and drawing his queen out early.

6. ... Pxb
7. Pxp

After plenty more thought. N-B3 looked possible. Clearly, following (say) 7B-Q3 Pxp & Pxp, my own pinned knight becomes vulnerable. 7Q-R5 also came in for some consideration. I already disliked the idea of castling kingside because of Alan's chances of attack along the open g-file. (7 Q-R5 looks a good idea -ed.).

7. ... QxP
8. N-B3 N-B3
9. B-N5

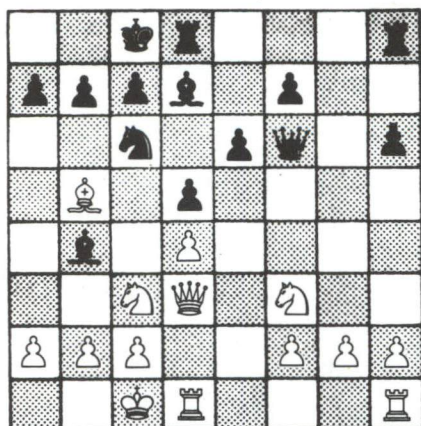
Alan said later that he had been hoping for this strategy on my part because he could refute it in a simple manner AND make progress towards queenside castling at the same time.

9. ... B-Q2
10. Q-Q3

I am reluctant to commit my queen but this move (a) made possible my own queenside castling (b) guarded both my knights and (c) linked my queen to my white-squared bishop.

10. ... O-O-O
11. O-O-O

I cannot remember the last game I either saw or took part in where BOTH players castled queenside!



11. ... BxN
12. QxB N-N1!

Looks negative but, in fact, this move set a lot of things in motion in Alan's favour. 13 BxB is pretty well forced on me, after which Alan's knight recaptures on d7, continuing thence to b6 with good future prospects on a4 and c4. All this was immediately predictable.

13. BxBch. NxB
14. K-N1

Players who castle queenside often live to regret it if they do NOT make this safety-first move at an early stage.

14. ... N-N3
Here it comes!

15. P-QN3
Sad, but more or less forced to prevent the knight's natural, menacing advance, as outlined above.

15. ... Q-K2
Alan tends to move his queen around rather a lot, but often to very good purpose. Here it aims at a3.

16. K-N2
To cover a3; but this move at the same time opens the way for my rooks to switch to the queenside.

16. ... R-Q3
I could see it coming. Ought I to move my queen off the c-file straight away?

17. R-QR1

No, I think I have a tempo for this useful move, with which I begin to lay claim to the a-file.

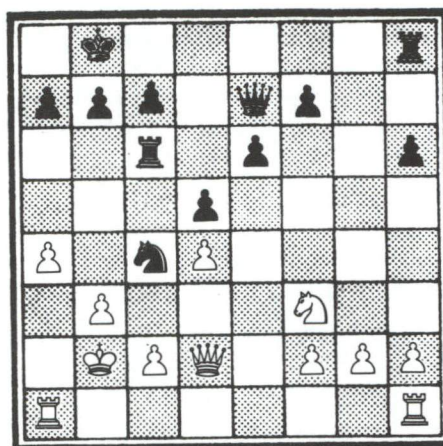
17. ... K-N1
18. P-QR4

Utilising another tempo to further my plan. Alan's knight is now starting to look rather embarrassed. He cannot halt my advance along the a-file by ...P-QR4 because my queen covers the a5 square.

18. ... R-b3
Of course.

19. Q-Q2
My queen retreats to a good square.

19. ... N-b5ch?!



Alan lunges! He gets only a pawn for his piece but look what a mess my defences are now in! He reckoned that to retreat his knight would have been too craven. I admire a player like Alan and enjoy my games with him because they seldom contain a dull moment.

20. PxN RxP

In our post-mortem, I remarked to Alan that maybe ...PxP would have been stronger, threatening a winning pawn-tork on the c-file, but we eventually concluded that his chosen move was better.

21. KR-QN1

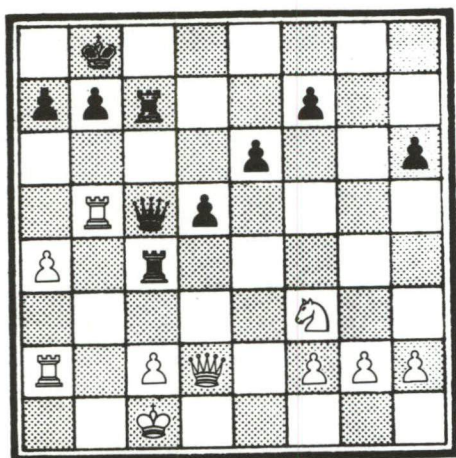
The sort of move I play with trickles of sweat running from my brow; the temptation is to use this move to get my queen off the open b-file straight away.

21. ... P-QB4
 "This," I told Alan, "must be the latest you've ever played this key move in the French Defence!" He has a clever and subtle idea. He wants to open up the c-file completely and then pile all his attacking forces on to it.

22. PxP QxP
 23. K-B1 R-QB1
 24. R-R2
 I have to reinforce the defence of c2. Later, Alan told me he had expected R-N2.

24. ... R-B2
 In the midst of attack, Alan has an eye to his defences as well, in best Karpovian style.

25. R-N5!
 This aggressive advance took Alan by surprise, and his reaction was the single most amazing move he has ever essayed against me.



25. ... RxPch!!
 I am stunned. Already down by a piece for a pawn, Alan appears to be throwing in the towel with this move. In fact, however, this kamikaze-like move "saves" the game for Alan. What's more, it leads fairly quickly to a winning position for him, because its shock-value is such that I miscalculate what to do next and have to give up my queen! Its

easy for YOU, sitting quietly as you read this, to say I naturally must re-take with my rook; but in the heat of the game all that I noticed was that, if I did that, then Alan would obtain a dangerous check on a3, leaving my c2 rook pinned against my king. So, wanting to keep a3 covered by my queen's rook, I played:-

26. QxR?
 The strange thing is that, when I had done this, Alan expressed agreement with me and said he thought it was indeed wiser of me to recapture this way. (Our games, as you can see, are played in a very amicable and - when appropriate - informal manner.) Later, in our post mortem, we concluded that 26 RxxR was better because it enabled me to retain my queen; but even then Alan may immediately have been able to get a draw starting with checks on a3 and next a1. (However, after 26...Q-R6+ 27K-N1 QxP 28R(5)-N2 white has little to show for the rook and knight. ed.)

Alan observed, "well, I'm a lot of material down now, aren't I?" I, blind to what was coming, agreed with him and pointed out that his queen was attacked as well. "Oh, I'm not worried about that," he retorted. "It's just a question of which of two squares to go to."

While he thought about this, I lounged back in my chair and couldn't restrain a bit of a laugh at a possible amusing continuation I'd just noticed (viz. 26...QxR leaving my queen pinned, to which I'd reply 27 QxR ch!!! winning outright).

26. ... Q-Q3!
 which wiped the smile right off my face.

27. QxRch.
 What else? Unfortunately, 27 RxxR ch. doesn't work because Alan simply recaptures with his king, not his rook, and his pin on the c-file remains on.

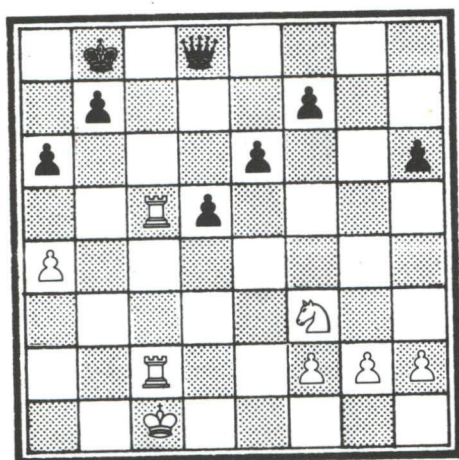
27. ... QxQch.
 28. R-B2 Q-Q1?

After so much enterprising, seemingly inspired play, Alan errs, missing 28 ... Q-KB5ch! winning my queen's rook pawn.

29. R(5)-B5
 tying Alan's queen to the back rank, or he may be mated next move (my knight covers his only checking square.)

29. ... P-R3
 Alan solves this particular problem easily.

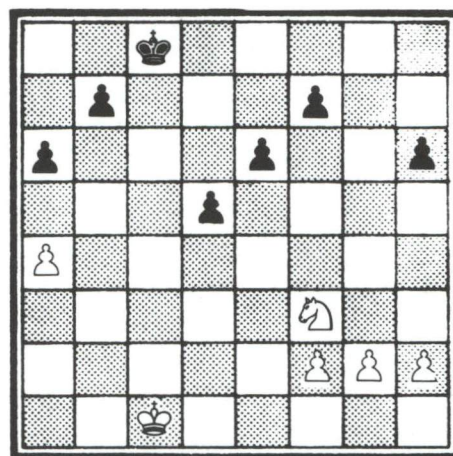
At this point the game enters a calmer phase but one in which Alan makes full use of his mobile queen against my exposed king. In material terms, he has a queen and two pawns against my knight and rook pair - not a serious deficit, especially when you note that Alan now has a powerful passed queen's pawn



NOTE B: Amateur players are often wary of entering into endings with a minor piece against several pawns because they fear that the pawns will be too strong. However, if the pawns are not too far advanced, and the enemy king not too active, the pawns can nearly always be blockaded. Then, because the defending side has only king and pawns, he nearly always runs out of moves - gets **ZUGSWANGED** - and has to give ground.

In this game white has the choice of winning the black queen for two rooks, leaving him in an ending with a knight against 2 pawns i.e.

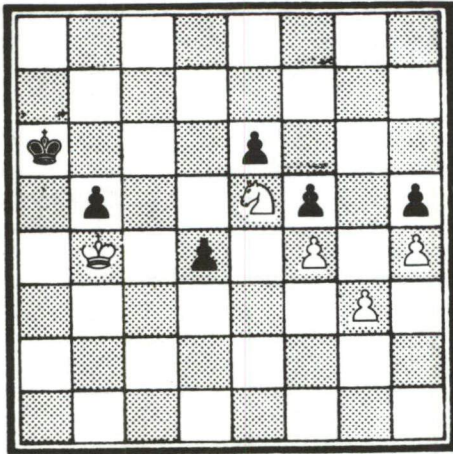
30. R-B8ch QxR
 31. RxQch KxR



White has two ways of trying to win this game; he can try and capture a black pawn - for example the pawn at h6 - and create his own passed pawn and hope to win with that. Or he can suppress the enemy pawns and gradually make black run out of moves.

The second plan is less messy and might go like this:-

32. N-K5 P-B4
 (if P-B3 33 N-N4 forks two pawns)
 33. p-B4 K-B2
 34. K-B2 P-N4
 35. PxP Pxp
 36. K-B3 K-N3
 37. K-N4 P-Q5
 38. P-N3 P-K4
 39. P-R4 K-R3

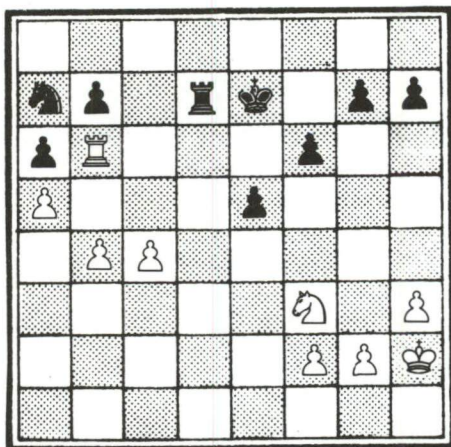


As we can see, black is almost completely out of moves; white has blockaded his pawns and they cannot advance. Now white can capture the pawns at leisure - for example:-

- | | |
|-------------|------|
| 40. K-B5 | K-R4 |
| 41. KxP | P-N5 |
| 42. K-B4 | K-R5 |
| 43. N-Q3 | P-N6 |
| 44. N-B5ch. | K-R6 |
| 45. NxP | |

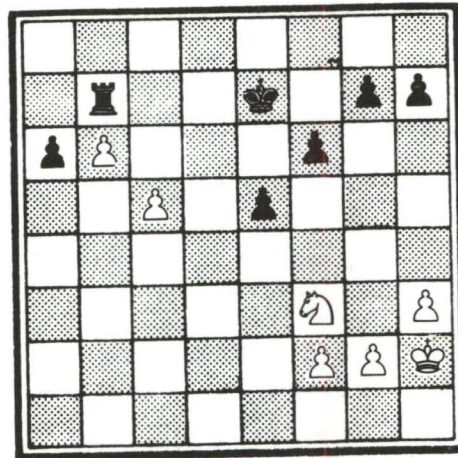
followed by mopping up the remaining black pawns and queening the white pawns.

Apropos this example of the knight defeating the pawns, white's success was in a large part due to the good use of his king. In a recent game which I had to adjudicate, the knight failed against the pawns for the reason that the defending king was far more powerful than the attacking king.



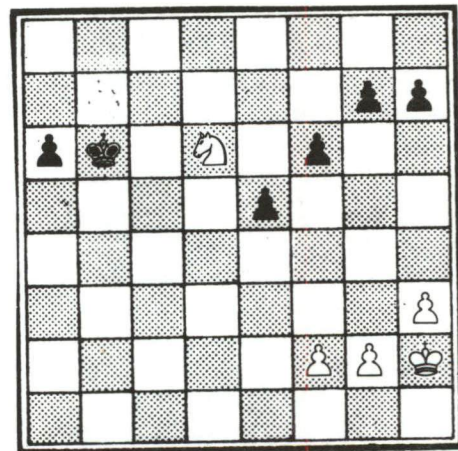
In this position black is able to trap the white rook, but the story does not end here.

- | | |
|---------|------|
| 1. P-N5 | N-B1 |
| 2. PxP | NxR |
| 3. PxN | PxP |
| 4. P-B5 | K-N2 |



Black is now the exchange up but the pawns look dangerous.

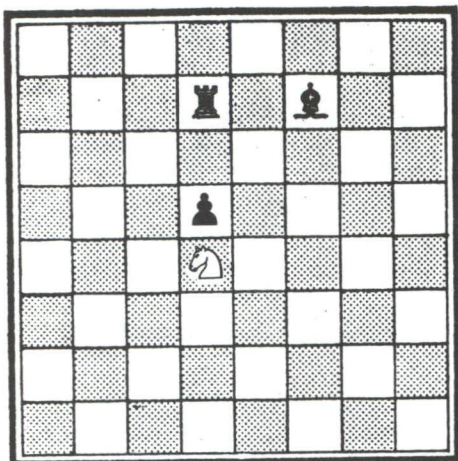
- | | |
|------------|------|
| 5. N-Q2 | K-Q2 |
| 6. N-B4 | K-B3 |
| 7. N-R5ch. | KxP |
| 8. NxR | KxP |
| 9. N-Q6 | |



White has a knight against two pawns, and I assumed this position as drawn, however, on appeal I agreed it was a win for black. The decisive factor is the miserable position of the white king and the powerful placing of

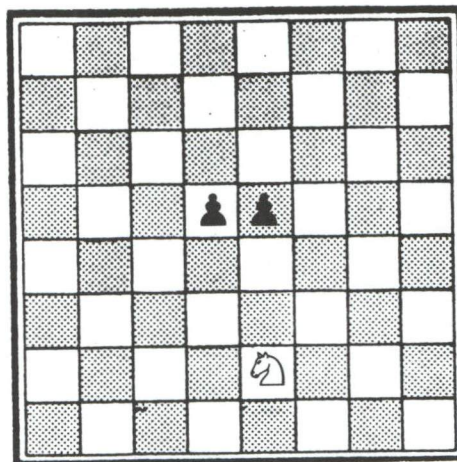
black's king, so that white's knight is pretty well defenceless against the march of the queen rook pawn. So the conclusion is - the king's placing is vital!

BLOCKADE: with regard to the word "blockade" that I used earlier in this section, it was first coined by Nimzowitsch in his book "The Blockade" which was a preliminary to his larger work "My System". Blockade here means "the mechanical obstruction of a piece by a pawn".



In the diagram the knight at d4 obstructs the pawn at d5, which is said to be "blockaded". This activity does not only have implications for the pawn, which cannot advance, but also affects the scope of the pieces. For example, the knight at d4 is itself better placed because it cannot be driven from the centre easily; and the black pieces behind the pawn at d5 find their lines obstructed by the pawn. In fact, the bishop at f7 is known as a "bad" bishop, because there is an immobile pawn in the centre on a square the same colour as the bishop, which seriously impedes her lines. A "bad" bishop can sometimes of itself cause the loss of the game. The rook, on the other hand, is not known as a "bad" rook, chiefly because it can shift to squares of the other colour.

Hence the side with the pawn strives to avoid being blockaded, because this stultifies his pawns and pieces, and thus two pawns abreast are a desirable feature.



These sorts of pawns are called "fluid" or "mobile". However, care must be taken to advance the right pawn. If black plays here 1...P-K5, he allows white to reestablish the blockade with 2 N-Q4; so the right advance would be 1...P-Q5, which prevents the blockade and maintains fluidity.

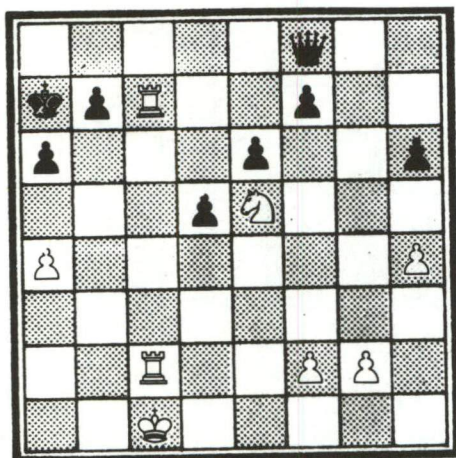
I have given an example with only a few pieces on the board but the idea can be applied to almost any position!

30. P-R4
to begin trying to restrict any kingside activity by Alan's queen, so that my knight can be released into the attack. (I intended an early P-N3.)

30. ... Q-KB1
An awkward-looking shuffle of a move, temporarily rendering Alan's queen harmless - or so I thought! It is the sort of move by Alan that restores my confidence against him when things have been going badly for me.

31. N-K5
My long dormant knight can spring into action, since Alan's queen on f8 threatens no checks whatever.

31. ... K-R2
 escaping to a good square and
 stepping clear of a knight fork on
 d7.



32. R-B7
 It's always a good idea to put a
 rook on the 7th rank, if you can,
 is it not? What I failed to see
 is that the path for Alan's queen
 to a3 is clear once more.

32. ... Q-R6ch.
 I'm in trouble from now on. Alan
 gets in no less than TEN checks in
 his next eleven moves, in the
 course of which he picks up both
 my hanging knight (which had been
 hanging around waiting to deliver
 check perhaps on c6 but never got
 there) and my queen's rook pawn to
 give himself a clearly winning
 position.

33. K-Q2 Q-N5ch.
 Better than ...QxP immediately.

34. K-B1 Q-K8ch!
 So that he can capture the knight
 with check.

35. K-N2 QxNch.
 36. K-R3 Q-R8ch.
 37. K-N3 Q-N8ch.
 38. K-R3

offering a draw. Alan said; "I'll
 try another move or two first, I
 think."

38. ... P-QR4

39. R-N2
 shutting off the threatened check
 on b4 and simultaneously making my
 own threats along the b-file.

39. ... Q-QR8ch
 Back come the checks by Alan not
 merely "saving checks" but checks
 that bring him ever more near to a
 handsome victory.

40. K-N3 Q-Q8ch
 It seems my king just cannot
 escape, flee where e'r it will.

41. K-R2 QxPch
 At this stage, Alan is clearly
 winning and my hopes of even a
 draw have become increasingly
 remote.

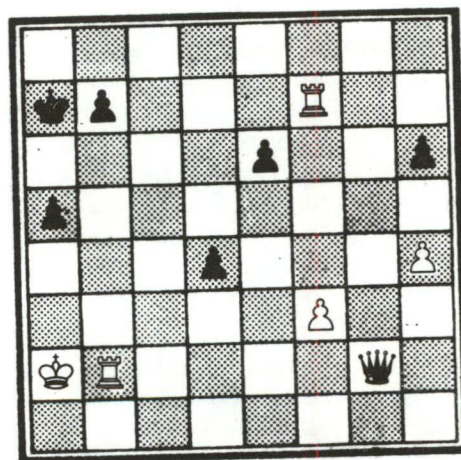
42. K-N1 Q-K5ch

43. K-R2 P-Q5!
 A fine move, even though quite
 foreseeable. Alan rams home his
 advantage by setting his passed
 pawn rolling and, simultaneously,
 protecting b7.

44. RxBP
 In the nature of a "spite"
 capture.

44. ... QxP?
 At the last fence Alan falls.

45. P-B3!



And we agreed a draw. In our
 post-mortem, it looked to me as
 though maybe Alan could have
 played on and retained winning
 chances but, a tired man, he might
 also have been mated. In any
 case, it was nearing midnight and
 we were both drained after such a
 fiery battle as this had been.

George v Victor Game 63 Sept.88

NOTE: Prior to the result of this game, George and I had completed 62 games, played mainly by telephone (all without any time limits). Our score was 31 points a piece! This suggests we are two of the most evenly matched players in Britain, although we bear comparison with those other contemporary chess "equals", Karpov and Kasparov, only alas in our level score.

1. P-KB4

Bird's Opening. A novelty in our games so far.

1 ...

P-K4

From's Gambit. The books say it is "sound" from black's point of view and is in some ways so strong that it explains why so few masters play 1. P-KB4 as their opening move. (Of course, there are plenty of other good reasons as well why white seldom opens in this way.)

2. PxP

Accepting the gambit. Later, George said he thought he'd have been better off to play 2. P-K4 converting the opening to a King's Gambit (with white offering the pawn, instead of black - how strange it is that the offer of a pawn for nothing can be stronger than the taking of a pawn for nothing....)

2. ...

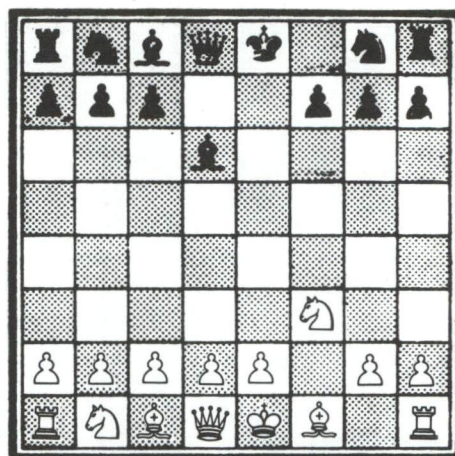
P-Q3

Black offers a further pawn "exchange" to obtain lots of space for his pieces in the centre and a slight lead in development.

3. PxP

BxP

4. N-KB3



NOTE C: From's Gambit derives its strength from the weakness of the white king side and the fact that black is always threatening nasty checkmates along the h5-e1 diagonal if white is unwary. In fact a game Crombleholme-Basman, around 1962 went now, 4...P-KN4 5 P-KR3?? B-N6 mate! White has to be careful, as black was threatening anyway 5...P-N5 6 N-N1 Q-R5ch 7P-N3 QxNPch! 8 PxQ BxP mate.

So after 4...P-KN4, white needs to choose either 5 P-KN3 P-N5 6N-R4 B-K2 7 N-N2 or 5 P-Q4, which gives the king a bolt hole at Q2 if necessary. After 5...P-N5, white can now play 6 N-N5 or 6 N-K5.

Apropos the weakness of the h5-e1 diagonal, the same idea was used in a recent game, Basman-Cohen, Westminster Quickplay - which ended in 8 moves! The opening was different, the colours were reversed, but still...

1. P-KN4

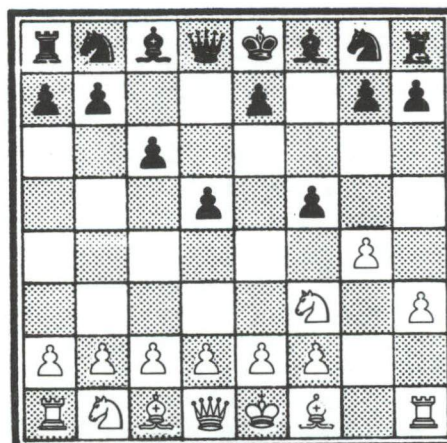
P-Q4

2. P-KR3

P-QB3

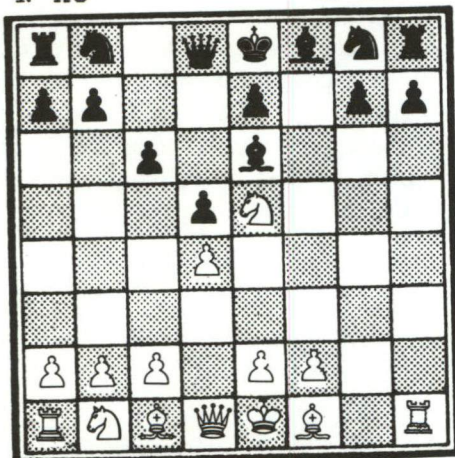
3. N-KB3

P-B4?!



4. P-Q4
5. PxP
6. N-K5

PxP
BxP
B-K3?



Here white could immediately have won the exchange by 7 N-N6, but with his next move he is angling for a bigger fish...

7. Q-Q3!? N-KB3?

Best was 7...Q-B1, to answer 8 RXP by ...B-B4

8. RXP!

and black had to resign, since if 8...NxR or 8...RxR 9 Q-N6 mates; and otherwise he simply loses a rook.

4. ... N-KB3
White hopes to be able to place his KR on the open f-file; but, whereas black is only one move away from castling, white is at least two. If black can impede or prevent white's kingside castling, black's yielding up of a pawn in the opening will unquestionably have been worthwhile.

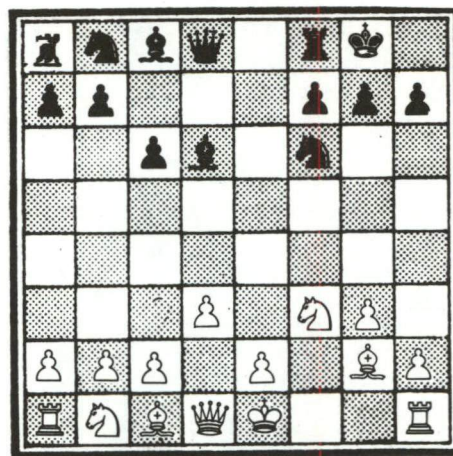
5. P-KN3
With the centre of the board unencumbered a fianchettoed bishop will be very strong.

5. ... O-O
A player who gambits a pawn away in the opening must develop rapidly and straightforwardly if he is to be able to exploit any temporary advantage which his gambit affords him.

6. B-N2

P-B3

This is normally thought of (for example, in the Caro-Kann) as "not a developing move"; but my idea is to bring my queen to QN3 where it will bear down on the long black diagonal towards George's king if he castles, that diagonal having been opened to me by George's choice of first move.



7. P-Q3

Natural, so as to begin getting out his queenside forces; but, in view of what followed, immediate castling might have been preferable for George.

NOTE D: 7.P-Q3? looks a very poor move as black can immediately attack the weakened square on K3 and also launch a strong attack along the a7-g1 diagonal with ...Q-N3 and ...N-N5.

7. ...

Q-N3

Now black CANNOT castle kingside!

8. QN-Q2

Remember that my queen on b6 bears down not only on the g1 square through and to which George would like to castle, but it also threatens the white queen's knight pawn, thus hampering development for the moment of George's queen bishop, which guards the pawn.

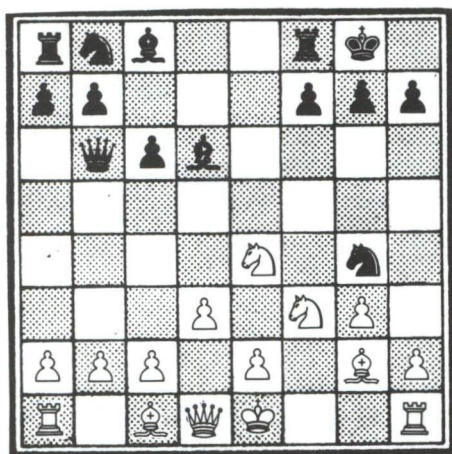
8. ...

N-N5!?

? for moving a piece twice in the opening (especially when I have just observed how important it is for the gambit-player to develop swiftly and straightforwardly); but ! for threatening mate in one and thereby effectively putting paid for ever to George's chances of castling kingside.

9. N-K4

Again a piece moves twice in the opening - this time to protect f2 and, incidentally, threaten my hanging bishop (although obviously this is a hollow threat for as long as black has the chance of mate on f2).



NOTE E: Perhaps black can do better with 9 ... B-N5ch. If now 10 P-B3 P-KB4 11 PxB PxN 12 PxP? Q-B7ch 13 K-Q2 R-Q1ch is devastating.

Or if 10 B-Q2 P-B4 11 BxB PxN 12 BxR? N-K6 13 Q-B1 NxBch 14 K-Q1 N-K6ch 15 K-K1 PxN and black is winning.

9. ...

B-B2

This looks rather craven at a juncture when black apparently needs to keep on developing fast; but c7 is a good square for my king bishop (it retains a goodish diagonal and on c7 doesn't impede development of my other forces). Also I reckoned that after 9...P-KB4 10 NxB my attack isn't strong enough.

10. R-KB1

"Good line for black, this From's Gambit," George admitted to me over the telephone. His 10th move, meaning his king must remain in the centre and leaving his queen bishop "stuck" defending b2 AND guarding against my forking threat with my knight on e3, recognizes that my attack still has great force.

10. ...

R-K1

At this point I thought, mistakenly, that George's e4 knight couldn't move; but with his rook defending f2 it COULD AND DID!

11. N-B2

N-QR3

Simple development again, rather than trying to exert pressure immediately by way of 11... N-K6?!

12. P-K4

Impeding the line on my rook.

12. ...

NxN

Deciding on an exchange so as to gain a tempo in which to develop my last minor piece. (12...P-KB4 looks good here; if 13 NxN PxP - ed.)

13. RxN

B-N5

My bishop has taken up a good square because if George tries to challenge it with P-KR3 I have the beautiful ...BxNP!

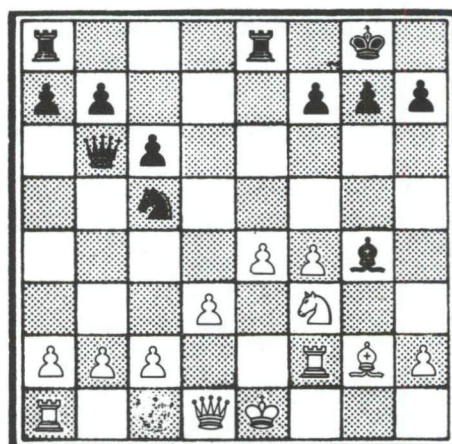
14. B-B4

BxB

This exchanges the bishop I'd been trying to safeguard but George's b-pawn is now under threat AND I gain another tempo in which to improve the position of my queen's knight.

15. PxB

N-B4



When I pointed out to George that I'd decided to adjure his b-pawn, he told me what he described as the "old story" of the wise uncle who left his chess-playing nephew a lot of money on condition that he must never risk capturing the queen's knight pawn with his queen!

16. Q-B1

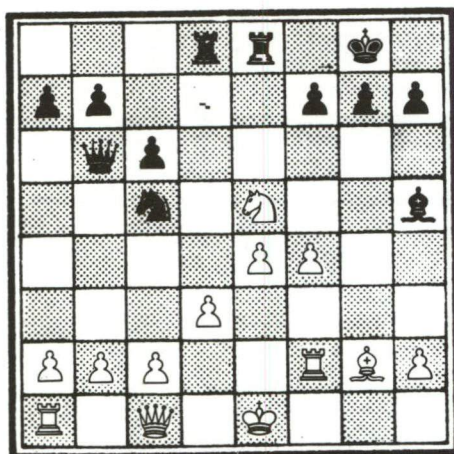
A computer-like move: awkward-looking but entirely logical - it simultaneously guards 2 unprotected pawns. But George's queen's rook is looking rather hemmed-in.

16. ... QR-Q1

The sort of move George and I call "a pipe-smoker".

17. N-K5

Ah, now I see; George's awkward-looking move 16 also had the result of releasing his knight from the pin on it.



This position I described to George and another of our friends as being, from my point of view, one of the most exciting I'd ever encountered in all my years of chess (playing, watching and reading). Why did I say this? It

was because I thought I espied the chance of a double rook-sacrifice enabling me to break through to victory. I ruefully admit I was wrong. I had got carried away by the fact that all my pieces were wonderfully placed, while George's forces weren't. Whether the line I chose actually missed chances of exploiting my superior troop-placings I must leave to others to judge.

My bishop is attacked. Should I (a) withdraw it to safety, (b) defend it by ...P-KR4, or (c) do something else?

17. ... RxN?

I chose (c) and soon realised my error. Up to this stage of the game, I'd been confident I was winning. But very rapidly after this, I became just as confident of losing. True I retained piece-activity, but if George could somehow get his queen's rook into the game I would stand the exchange and a pawn to the bad - a deficit big enough to make eventual defeat almost certain.

18. PxR

"Your exchange-sacrifices have worked well in the past against me," remarked George as he took the rook. This has indeed been the case, but those exchange sacrifices were better thought-out than this one.

NOTE F: Unfortunately white does not have quite enough for a clear victory with his rook sacrifice.

He can try on move 18, instead of ...Q-N5ch, 18 ... RxP! ? hoping for 19. PxR?? NxQPch forking king and queen. But after 18...RxP white can smartly defend with 19 Q-B4 B-R4 20 K-B1 and black's attack fizzles out.

18. ... Q-N5ch
This is the key continuation after my sacrifice. George had several ways of responding to the check. I calculated that all the responses were bad for him EXCEPT ONE. (See whether you agree with me!)

19. K-B1!
...and good old George opts for the defence which was the best one ...

19. ... Q-Q5
Another queen move, I confess, but I am still hopefully angling for a new sacrifice (on d3) and also hope perhaps to pickup George's weak pawn on e5 to claw back a little bit of my material deficit.

20. Q-N5
I had expected Q-B4. George's choice of move is a bit unsubtle, even for me (if the nephew in the story takes the white b-pawn with his queen, he loses not only his inheritance but also suffers the ignominious 21 QxR mate !!!) George's queen move to g5 (or to f4) can be answered in only one satisfactory way.

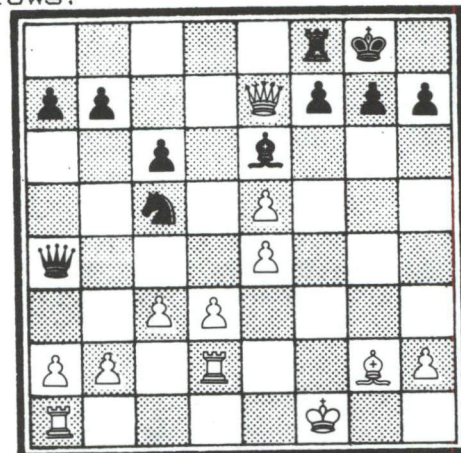
20. ... B-K3
21. R-Q2
Preparing to harry my queen and defending against a possible knight sacrifice by me on d3. This looked a quite reasonable move at the time but I now think, with hindsight, that the other rook should have moved to the centre of the board instead on George's move 21 and to hell with his a-pawn!

21. ... R-KB1
Solid. Have my attempts at adventure in this tussle come to a drab end? (I still stand the exchange and a pawn down and appear to have lost the initiative completely.) My move reinforces f7 and frees my queen from the rooks defence.

22. P-B3
Biting my queen's ankles, as George put it. Retreat along the d-file looks supine, so I try
22. ... Q-R5

The key asset I get from this move is a mite oblique; it's the pin on George's a-pawn. For example, if P-N3? B(or N)xNP!

23. Q-K7?
This move, lively and apparently sound in itself, turned out to be the turning point of the game. George attacks my knight which is tempted back to the defensive square d7 or the b-pawn is lost. BUT George's queen, by moving deep into my camp, gets cut off from any important role in what follows.



23. ... N-N6!
Forking George's rooks and, therefore, winning back the exchange (see my note to my move 22). When I asked George whether he'd foreseen this move by me, he said, yes, but he reckoned he'd just give me back some material and then be OK. A grave miscalculation I fear, and a yielding back of material to me that I don't think was forced on George in any way.

24. R(1)-Q1 NxR
25. RxN QxRP

For the moment I've got all my material back and retain two solid advantages which can be traced all the way back to my "misguided" sacrifice on move 17, viz., (a) George's doubled pawns, and (b)

the fact that the blocked backward one of them itself shuts in George's fianchettoed bishop. My king is safe now. His isn't. My bishop is strong; his is nowhere much. My rook (opposite his king on a line which can easily be opened up) in fine. His is miserable. Thus, I was winning the first phase of this game (till move 17), clearly losing thereafter in the second phase (till move 23) and now the game has been transformed once more and we enter its third phase.

26. QxNP

We've had games before, George and I, in which I allow him to pawn-grab while I pursue a vain attack on some other part of the board. Will this be any different, this game in which I've already thought to espy one "winning attack" which was illusory?

26. ...

Q-N8ch!

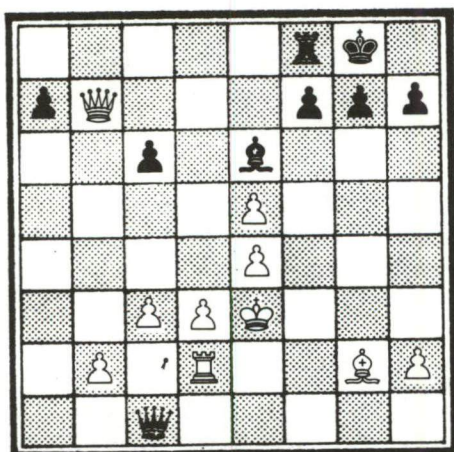
Much more active (with an eye to the immediate future) than ... Q-R8ch, which was why I didn't mind leaving my a-pawn unguarded.

27. K-B2

Q-QB8

28. K-K3

Had George played 28 R-K2, then ... Q-KB5ch forks two loose pawns. I'd say that whatever he played, he was still in trouble.



What should black play next? I like to believe that I learn something from each game - this is certainly the case in games I lose! From this particular game, I learnt that checks, although inviting for the attacking player, are NOT always the best way to further an assault. Here, for instance, I have checking possibilities on e1 and g1 (in the latter case winning George's h-pawn if I want to take it); but in both lines George interposes his rook. Aren't I, then, better off to leave his rook pinned and bring up another cannon against him? Yes.

28. ...

B-N5!

This almost wins outright, I thought, as I now threaten 29...Q-K8 ch!! winning George's rook which can't be interposed because my intermediate bishop move has not the e2 square covered.

I was wrong though. My move was good, but George found an ingenious defence which, in my excitement, I'd not foreseen.

29. P-Q4!

So that George's king can march round the rook, if I give check on e1. "You have a perpetual now, I think, if you want it," said George, "so I'm willing to agree a draw in this position. Look at it and let me know." The chess player as con-artist. I didn't have to look.

Again, should I play check on e1 or g1? I decided NO. I wanted George's rook to remain firmly pinned. What else then? George threatens both my queenside pawns.

29. ...

P-QB4!?

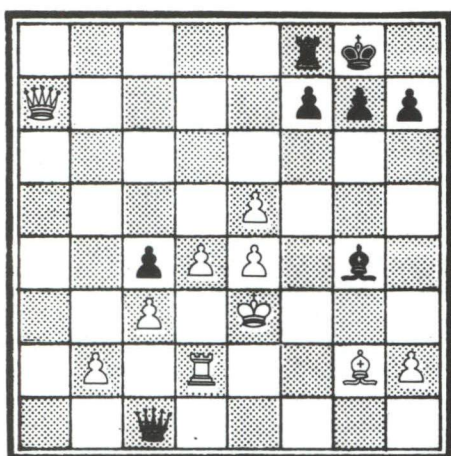
This is the sort of move which can turn out to be too clever by half. It saves the more important of my threatened pawns because if 30. PxP? then ... R-Q1! looks jolly strong (...QxR can't be prevented). If George leaves his queen pawn where it is, on the other hand, ...PxP ch looks good.

The risk I took was 30 P-Q5, making George's queen pawn a passed pawn; but even then, after 30...P-B5! George's rook will become indefensible.

30. QxRP

"I'll be greedy again," observed George, swallowing another queen-side pawn and threatening my remaining one.

30. ... P-B5!



The main risk I had been running of late in this game was that George would somehow create a mass of passed pawns on the queenside whose eventual stampede forward would drive me into a difficult defensive posture. This move, however, means that, although George appears to have five pawns against one (!), you'll notice on closer inspection that he has only one passed pawn, and that one is on a file he dare not weaken because his pinned rook is vulnerable along it. Moreover, my move gives me vital control of the d3 square.

31. B-B3?

Desperation. 31 P-R3 offers me the exchange, but this move gives me the whole rook which, for the last several moves, I've been aiming at.

31. ... BxB
Exploiting George's "overloaded" king.

32. KxB QxR
33. Resigns

I have a rook for two pawns, I fork two more pawns, and my king is utterly safe.

(A fascinating game - ed.).

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